

The Claremont City Council held a meeting on Wednesday, January 10, 2018, in the Council Chambers of City Hall.

The meeting was called to order by Mayor Lovett at 6:30 p.m.

Members of the Council present were:

At-Large Councilor Claire Lessard
Ward I Councilor Andrew O'Hearne
Ward III Councilor Jonathan Stone
Assistant Mayor Allen Damren
Mayor Charlene Lovett
At-Large Councilor Jeremy Zullo
At-Large Councilor Abigail Kier
At-Large Councilor Nicholas Koloski
Ward II Councilor Scott Pope

Also present:

Ryan McNutt, City Manager

AGENDA CHANGES

None

REPORT OF THE SECRETARY

A motion was made by Ms. Kier and seconded by Mr. Damren to accept the minutes of the December 13, 2017, City Council meeting as amended.

Mayor Lovett said on page 13, top paragraph, to add for clarification, that the proposed ordinance and resolution cited energy committee or commission was comprised of five people.

Mr. O'Hearne said on page 4 that Ms. Towle had asked what the process was to determine the new Fire Chief.

Mr. Koloski said on page 4, he was inquiring what the policy was for training first responders to use Narcan.

Voice vote: motion carried 9-0.

MAYOR'S NOTES

Mayor Lovett said the First Night event was a success. She thanked the sponsors: Claremont-Sugar River Rotary Club, Claremont Savings Bank, Lake Sunapee Bank, Mascoma Savings Bank, McGee Toyota, Sears Hometown Store, Hubert's, Goodrich Oil, Curt Insurance, Biron's Flooring, Townline Equipment, Ink Factory, KM Early CPA, Stringer Funeral Home, American Plate Glass, Claremont Custom Framing and Pleasant Street Antiques. She thanked everyone in the community for participating.

Mark Brislin, Parks and Recreation Director, said this was another great year for the First Night Celebration. Over 600 people went through the CSB Community Center. Arrowhead numbers were down because of the cold weather. Other locations were well attended. This event made WMUR's Top 5 Things To Do on New Year's Eve list. Mayor Lovett gave her thanks to the staff who worked on this.

Mayor Lovett said SB247, the lead bill, was on its way to the Senate. She said she will ask the Councilors at the end of the meeting if they wish to sign and send a letter of support.

Mayor Lovett said a meeting will be held regarding the Wild Goose boat access on Lake Sunapee. She, Don Clarke and Keith Raymond will attend.

Mayor Lovett said HB561, relative to contributions by retirement system employers for certain full-time positions changed to part-time or interim employment and relative to enforcement of provisions concerning retired members working part-time after retirement, would be brought up under Future Agenda Items as it may have a future impact on the City.

Mayor Lovett talked about a veterinarian in Lebanon who is hosting a project run by KUA to test household pets for lead poisoning. She said that is a good data point to see if family members are being poisoned.

Mayor Lovett said January 15 is Martin Luther King (MLK) Day. The schools are doing programs on Tuesday. She read an excerpt from MLK's speech for his Nobel Peace Prize acceptance. There will be a potluck soup & bread lunch at noon at the Episcopal Church; members of the public are invited.

Mr. Damren said the Greater Claremont Chamber of Commerce announced its President's Award winners: Young Professional – Sean Roberts; Model Youth – Prescott Herzog; Non-Profit – Southwestern Community Services, Business – Ink Factor; and Citizen – Chuck Allen.

Mr. McNutt said the City can do more for Martin Luther King (MLK) Day than is currently done. He has asked the Library Director to make all books and other materials on MLK available in a certain area next week.

CITY MANAGER'S REPORT

Mr. McNutt said there would be limited parking at the Claremont Savings Bank Community Center (CSBCC) on Saturday, January 13, because they are hosting a youth basketball tournament and a swim meet. People are asked to use the Claremont Middle School and Arrowhead parking areas.

Mr. McNutt said Sunday, February 4, there will be a 5K run/walk, kids will start at 10:30 a.m.

Mr. McNutt talked about City land that a farmer has been using and that a resolution for transfer of this land with considerations is being worked out.

Mr. McNutt said it has been bitterly cold and that the CSBCC is available as a warming center. When the CSBCC is closed, Valley Regional Hospital (VRH) is making its emergency room lobby available for a warming center. He thanked VRH CEO Peter Wright and VRH for allowing the use of their space.

Mr. McNutt said regarding Project 439, Needle Exchange, that there is no information for a new location at this time. Peter Wright is working to see if VRH can be the location. The best alternate site would be the Hope for Recovery Center, however, the school has a program in the same building which makes it a school site and therefore, not available. Efforts to find a location will continue.

Mayor Lovett thanked the department heads for the more comprehensive reports. She would like clarification of the assessed valuation. She had heard it was \$701 million and the Finance Report has it listed at \$704 million. Regarding the appearance of declining membership at the CSBCC, she would like to know what steps are in the works and what are the recommendations from the Parks & Recreation Commission. Mr. McNutt said he and Parks and Recreation Director Mark Brislin have reviewed this. The trend line for memberships is holding steady at just under 1,500. Some months it dips and then comes back up. Mr. Damren said that over the last four months it seems to have stabilized. Mayor Lovett said we are still within the \$500,000 budget. Just keep that in mind for the budget. Mr. McNutt said for all of 2017, the CSBCC spent only 92% of its budget and it only had 86% of its expected expenditures. Mayor Lovett said according to the proforma, it is typical for membership to decline.

Mr. Pope thanked the City Manager and Mayor for getting the warming shelters opened.

APPOINTMENT TO BOARDS AND COMMITTEES

Claremont Development Authority

A motion was made by Mr. Damren and seconded by Mr. Koloski to re-appoint Michael Satzow to seat 9 of the Claremont Development Authority.

Voice vote: motion carried 9-0.

Claremont Energy Advisory Committee

A motion was made by Mr. Pope and seconded by Mr. Koloski to appoint Rebecca MacKenzie to seat 2 of the Claremont Energy Advisory Committee.

Voice vote: motion carried 9-0.

CITIZEN'S FORUM

Rebecca MacKenzie, Ward 2, talked about the Martin Luther King Day programs. Trinity Episcopal Church will have a noon soup and bread potluck meal. They will share the MLK Nobel Peace Prize acceptance speech and will close with a few songs. They will finish around 2 p.m. She said February is Black History Month and the Racial Healing Working Group is inviting folks to develop events to raise awareness. She can be contacted at Reb178@myfairpoint.net.

Mayor Lovett asked about snowstorms in the Public Works Report. Mr. McNutt said the actual winter maintenance budget is at \$165,000. We are at 45% of the overtime budget and almost 40% of the winter maintenance budget. Last year there were 30 winter events and as of now we have had 14 events. Mayor Lovett noted that some Public Works people had to give up some of their holidays to take care of the storms.

When Sergeant-at-Arms Scott Pope asked about the five-minute time-limit for Marion Lovett's presentation, Mayor Lovett asked that the Council suspend that rule, if it takes more than five-minutes.

Marion Lovett, former School Board Student Representative, Stevens High School graduate and current freshman at Roanoke College in Virginia said there have been discussions about reducing the tax rate. To do that, you have to broaden the tax base and part of that is having people move to Claremont. Families are concerned about the school district. She showed a PowerPoint, "Claremont School District Ratings and Reviews." She said the ratings online are not looking good. The website, Great Schools!, lists Claremont schools as 4 or 3 out of 10 (information is from 2014). She said Math and College readiness are reported as below average. She said SchoolDigger, another website, has ranked Claremont 152 out of 229. She said Claremont is not being well represented online and that surrounding area schools are rated higher than Claremont. Other websites she talked about was Niche and Google Review. She said on Google Review that Claremont Middle School had a lot of comments regarding bullying. Miss Lovett said she made the PowerPoint to show to the joint session of the Council and School Board, but would have to leave to go back to school before that meeting would be held, so she chose to show it at this Council meeting.

Mr. McNutt asked if updated data could be given to the websites. Miss Lovett suggested reaching out directly to the websites. Miss Lovett said NH is one of only six states that do not report to these websites.

Mr. McNutt talked about the “Zillow effect” and wondered where they got their data.

Mayor Lovett requested that this presentation be sent to Ms. Russell for distribution to the Council.

Mayor Lovett said when the Council meets with the School Board, she thought this would be a priority. The City cannot be successful without an outstanding school district and outstanding City services.

Mr. Pope said, regarding bullying, that it is being worked on by parents and administrators.

Mr. McNutt asked that when residents express their opinions online to take extra care because the results can be far reaching.

Rebecca MacKenzie, Ward 2, said the school district is working very hard on bullying. She asked if there is some way the school and/or City could put on the City’s website more up-to-date information about what is happening in the school district.

Mayor Lovett said that may be a topic at the joint meeting, i.e. how to report City/school strengths.

Ms. Kier said regarding Google Reviews, that the school can respond to reviews.

Mr. McNutt said he will bring this up to School Superintendent Dr. Middleton McGoodwin.

NEW BUSINESS

Resolution 2018-20 Accept \$8,000 from McGee Toyota for July 4th Fireworks Display – Public Hearing

The City of Claremont would like to have a July 4th Fireworks Display and the cost will be \$10,000.00. The City has received a donation of \$8,000.00 from McGee Toyota for the Fireworks Display with the remaining \$2,000 already collected during last year’s fireworks celebration. This is a request to accept the donation and authorize its expenditure for the Fireworks Display (with no impact on the tax rate).

Mark Brislin, Parks and Recreation Director, said the Fireworks Display line item was eliminated from this current budget. Parks and Recreation started fundraising at this past July 4th Fireworks Celebration where they raise over \$2,000. Dave Higgins from McGee Toyota, on behalf of Rob McGee, presented an \$8,000 check to the City.

A motion was made by Mr. Koloski and seconded by Mr. Damren to adopt Resolution 2018-20 Accept \$8,000 from McGee Toyota for July 4th Fireworks Display.

Mr. Koloski read the resolution into the record.

Mayor Lovett opened the public hearing. No one spoke. She closed it.

Roll call vote:

Lessard - yes

O’Hearne - yes

Stone - yes

Damren - yes

Zullo - yes

Kier - yes

Koloski - yes

Pope - yes

Lovett – yes

Motion carried 9-0.

Ordinance 559 Establish Maple Avenue School Zones – First Reading

The purpose of this proposed change is to establish school zones for speed limit purposes. All school zones are within 1,000 feet of a primary or secondary school and have been identified as zones needing reduced speed limits during opening and closing school time periods.

Enactment of this Ordinance will revise Chapter 19, Traffic and Motor Vehicles by adding provisions to establish posted school zones to reduce speed limits at the beginning and end of the school day.

Mr. Damren read the explanation of proposed action into the record.

A motion was made by Mr. Damren and seconded by Ms. Kier to adopt Ordinance 559 Establish Maple Avenue School Zones on first reading with the correction noted by Chief Chase.

Police Chief Mark Chase gave a brief explanation. Residents around Maple Avenue School felt drivers were speeding in the area. City Code doesn’t specify school zones. The Police Department recommends areas around the schools be designated as school zones. There is not a lot of additional signage needed. He will work with the Public Works Department for posting school zone signs. He noted there was a typographical error on the draft ordinance. Under Disnard School, Maple Avenue and Barton Way needed to be deleted. Chief Chase said he did not name private schools in case the names changed.

Mr. O’Hearne asked about enforcement. Chief Chase said it will be under state law.

Mayor Lovett asked if the Traffic Advisory Committee looked at this. Chief Chase said it was sent to legal counsel for review. Mayor Lovett asked if the Policy Committee was okay to go forward with this. Ms. Kier and Mr. Pope nodded

Voice vote: motion carried 9-0.

Motion to Apply for \$284,985 NH Dept. of Emergency Management Hazard Mitigation Grant

A motion was made by Mr. Pope and seconded by Ms. Kier to authorize the City Manager, or his designees, to apply to the New Hampshire Department of Safety – Division of Homeland Security and Emergency Management for a \$284,985 Hazard Mitigation Grant for drainage improvements to the Tyler Brook Corridor.

Victor St. Pierre, Public Works Assistant Director, said this is a FEMA (Federal Emergency Management Agency) grant to fix the culvert that goes under Tyler Street. It will accommodate a 50-year stormwater flow. If awarded, FEMA will pay 75% and the City will pay 25%.

Mr. McNutt said the 25% (\$70,000) is in the Public Works budget.

Mr. Koloski asked if this culvert goes under the building. Mr. St. Pierre said yes. Mr. Koloski asked if the City has to do anything with the building. Mr. St. Pierre said the City may have to move the culvert.

Voice vote: motion carried 9-0.

Water & Sewer Infrastructure Update

Mr. St. Pierre showed a PowerPoint presentation, City of Claremont Water/Wastewater Departments.

- The City gets its water from the Whitewater Reservoir.
- Regarding the Whitewater Forestry, the goal is to work on the over-mature forest to make it healthy again.
- Rice Reservoir is used for reserve storage.
- This year Public Works will clean the pipe from the Whitewater Reservoir to the Dole Reservoir. The Dole Reservoir is a holding reservoir. The intent is to reduce the amount of water coming from the Sugar River by cleaning that pipe. It is a 17,000-foot pipe. The City has received an estimate of \$600,000 to clean the pipe.
- The water treatment plant processes a daily average of 1.1 million gallons.

Mr. McNutt asked what the water treatment plant capacity is. Mr. St. Pierre said it is designed for 2.2 million gallons a day, so we are at 50%.

Mr. Zullo asked about the cost to replace/upsized the line from Whitewater to Dole. Mr. St. Pierre said it is roughly \$1.5 million. If we can clean the pipe, we can put in a water turbine on the end of that pipe where it goes into Dole which will create energy to feed the water treatment plant.

- The Moody water tank is used for fire suppression.
- Lead line improvements – In 2017, the Water Department completed multiple projects.
- The Main Street Project has gone out to bid. It extends from Esersky's Bridge to Opera House Square. All the services in that area will be replaced as part of this project.
- Water meters are being replaced to accommodate drive-by readings.
- Goals for Water:
 - o Clean raw water from Whitewater into Dole
 - o Remove all 68 lead water service lines
 - o Complete asset management plan/GIS system
 - o Replace distribution lines and loops
 - o Identify leaks in distribution system
 - o Replace water meters
 - o Repair Whitewater spillway dam
 - Will come back to the Council to get money from the forestry funds
 - o Cut trees around Whitewater Reservoir

Mr. St. Pierre said Public Works has notified everyone affected that they have lead lines.

Mayor Lovett commended the Public Works Department for all they are doing on the lead removal. She said the protocols this department established for protecting citizens from the potential of lead in their water is being used throughout the state. Mr. St. Pierre said one of his protocols is listed on the Boston website and EPA has picked it up as well.

- Wastewater Treatment Plant (WWTP) – processes 1.3 million gallons per day (which is .2 million more than water because APC Paper draws water from the river and disposes to the WWTP).
- Solar Energy – WWTP. Panels going in in March. Cost of the project will be paid with the savings. Supplies 20% of the energy the plant needs.
- Goals – Sewer
 - o Complete upgrades to the WWTP
 - o Complete inspections & infiltrations of all sewer lines
 - Trying to find the leaks
 - o Achieve compliance by 10/2018 with all EPA regulations
 - o Purchase jetter to clean sewer pipes (increase efficiency)
- 2017 Accomplishments – Water & Sewer
 - o Numerous water lead lines replaced – SRF
 - o Water leak detection program – training
 - o Progress replacing water meters
 - o Completed the Rice Reservoir spillway
 - o Completed design for Whitewater spillway
 - o Completed water line plan – Whitewater to Dole

- o GIS storm water and wastewater plan in place
- o Energy audit @ WWTP completed
- o Main Street water & sewer project – contract
- o Completed WWTP asset management plan
- Do not dump grease down the drain.

Mr. St. Pierre said the Water and Sewer Departments are both self-funded.

Mr. O’Hearne asked about tracking the pipes by GPS. Mr. St. Pierre said every fire hydrant and manhole is on GPS and the pipes between the manholes are usually straight.

Mayor Lovett said there needs to be a review of the water and sewer rates and perhaps in February Public Works would come back to Council with information to see if the rates are sufficient.

Mr. St. Pierre said a big expense is coming, which was included in the rate increase, and that is to replace the pipe from Whitewater to Dole. If they are successful with their plan, they hope the cost will be under \$100,000 versus the \$1.5 million for a replacement.

Mayor Lovett asked when there are water/sewer breaks, to put that information on the Monthly Report and to include how many breaks that line has had in the past.

Mr. Koloski asked for some sort of graphic to be posted in City Hall showing the Main Street Reconstruction Project.

Discussion of City Council Strategic Plan – Goals and Objectives for 2018

Mayor Lovett asked Councilors to review the Goals & Objectives for the January 24th Council meeting. Some items that were mentioned to be added to the list were lead; whether or not the previous goals had been met; housing; City’s assessed value (Mr. McNutt thought this was a good goal); meeting the requirements of MS4; workforce development; and better online presence.

Mr. Koloski asked for an update on the Business Development Coordinator. He would like an update on what is being done in the Planning office. Mr. McNutt will coordinate with Mr. Koloski regarding the Planning and Development Department’s Report to see what he’s seeking.

Mayor Lovett asked Mr. McNutt for an update on the items not italicized (italicized items are Council action/directives).

Mr. Koloski asked if someone is going to the businesses to ask what the City can do for them.

Overview of Evaluation Process for City Manager

Mayor Lovett asked that a copy of the City Manager’s contract be placed in the Council packet.

COMMITTEE REPORTS

Mayor Lovett would like to have better communication between the boards and Council. She will draft a letter to be sent to the boards suggesting ways to communicate.

FUTURE AGENDA ITEMS AND DIRECTIVES

Council asked for a list of all boards with Councilor vacancies. Mayor Lovett asked for it to be placed in the January 24th Council packet and to include the Council-appointed ad hoc committees.

Mr. Pope asked for an updated list of debt service and to include the bonds as well.

Mr. Pope asked for an update on what the Emergency Management Plan is. Mr. McNutt said it was last updated in 2015. He said he can ask Bryan Burr, Fire Chief as well as Emergency Manager, to speak about it.

Mr. Pope asked for examples of lead policies from Mayor Lovett.

There was a discussion about the City Manager giving a brief verbal summary of his report and being able to keep to Mayor Lovett's commitment to end the meetings no later than 9:30 p.m.

Mr. Koloski would like an update after the Planning office has reached out to businesses to find out what they need, i.e. workforce housing, as that would affect Council goals.

Mayor Lovett would like a presentation from Police Chief Mark Chase on police retention. She said in the last monthly report, Public Works stated there were issues at the new Ford location and at NFR. She asked what those issues were.

Mayor Lovett said at the first meeting in February, there will be a discussion of the water and sewer rates.

Mayor Lovett asked for an update on the voting banner requested by Mr. Koloski.

Mayor Lovett asked Mr. McNutt to schedule a Council tour.

CONSULTATION WITH LEGAL COUNSEL

None

Mr. Koloski asked about meeting with other neighboring governing bodies, i.e. Lebanon. Mayor Lovett said she would add it to the Council goals list.

Mr. O'Hearne said Mark Materuso was retiring from the Police Department after 20 years.

Mayor Lovett said it would be nice to notify the Council of academy graduations, retirements, and promotions, as part of the Department Reports.

ADJOURNMENT

At 9:38 p.m., a motion was made by Mr. O’Hearne and seconded by Mr. Stone to adjourn.

Voice vote: motion carried 9-0.

Respectfully Submitted,

Dorée M. Russell
Clerk to the Council